indeed it is scared of a discussion in Parliament on Adani," he told reporters after his LS speech. He further took a dig at the Modi government saying the much talked about "Amrit Kaal" is actually a "Mitr (friend) Kaal".

For now, the Opposition seems united against Modi, but several undercurrents are visible. The Congress seems to have the support of anti-BJP parties on the Adani issue, but regional heavyweights such as the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and Trinamool Congress (TMC) are reluctant to come under a Congress umbrella, preferring to lead their own battles. For instance, when the Congress called a meeting to discuss Opposition strategy in Parliament, Mamata Banerjee's TMC skipped it. And while the Congress and other parties decided to take part in parliamentary proceedings from February 8, AAP and BRS stayed away as a JPC has not been ordered.

PLAYING ON THE FRONT FOOT

For someone who has been extremely vocal about bringing economic offenders to book, PM Modi has so far avoided talking about the Adani allegations directly. Indeed, the PM's gameplan from the beginning was to make the case that Rahul's charges were aimed at him personally, questioning his commitment to the people, his integrity, the schemes that he had launched, and the general "positivity" he had brought about in the country. Taking a dig at Rahul's comment that Harvard University might do a case study on the "Adani scam", the PM said that the American university has already done a study titled 'In the Name of Democracy? The Rise and Decline of India's Congress Party'. Without directly referring to Rahul's allegation that he had coerced the governments in Bangladesh and Sri Lanka to give contracts to the Adani Group, PM Modi said: "The Opposition leaders contradict their own statements. They say India's global image has weakened since 2014. But they also say that India bullies foreign governments. They must make up their mind...."

Like the PM, other senior BJP leaders have also skirted direct allusions to a Modi-Adani connection. Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman dismissed concerns that the controversy will alarm global investors, saying India's financial markets are "very well regulated". Parliamentary affairs minister Prahlad Joshi maintained that there was no connection between the Adani affair and the government. BJP MP Nishikant Dubey was the only one to take the bull by the horns: "If you can prove that after becoming PM, Modiji travelled even once with Adani, I'll resign."

Why is there a demand for a JPC?

A Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) is a special committee set up by Parliament for the detailed scrutiny of a subject or Bill. To set up a JPC, a motion is passed in one House and supported by the other House. Another way to form a JPC is for the two presiding chiefs of both Houses to communicate with each other to institute one

Composition: A JPC comprises members of both ruling and Opposition parties, from both Houses of Parliament.

Mandate: A JPC's mandate is decided during the motion. The committee is authorised to collect evidence in oral or written form or demand documents related to the matter. If a witness fails to appear before the JPC, his conduct amounts to contempt of the House. The proceedings and findings of the committee are confidential, except in matters of public interest. The JPC is dissolved when the task is completed.

Power: JPC recommendations have persuasive value but the committee cannot force the government to take any action. The government may decide to launch fresh investigations on a JPC report. It is required to report on the follow-up action taken on the recommendations of the JPC and other panels. The panels then submit 'Action Taken Reports' in Parliament based on the government's reply. These reports can be discussed in Parliament and the government can be questioned.

Past JPCs: JPCs have been set up several times to probe various matters, including the Bofors scandal (1987), the Harshad Mehta stock market scam (1992), the Ketan Parekh share market scam (2001), the soft drink pesticide issue (2003), the 2G spectrum case (2011) and the VVIP chopper scam (2013). They have also been formed to examine several Bills and crucial issues such as the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement (RFCTLARR) Act, 2013; the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2015; the Enforcement of Security Interest and Recovery of Debts Laws and Miscellaneous Provisions (Amendment) Bill, 2016; the Financial Resolution and Deposit Insurance Bill, 2017; the Citizenship (Amendment) Bill, 2016; the Personal Data Protection Bill, 2019; the Biological Diversity (Amendment) Bill, 2021; and the Office of Profit, 2022.